PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Chevrolet K5 Blazer (1973–1991)

1973–1991 · K5 · K10 / V10 Blazer · GMC Jimmy · M1009 CUCV

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Frame cracks at the steering box**
  This is the classic K5 fault. On CK5 and GMSquareBody, owners say the frame cracks around and behind the steering-box bolts, often on the inside of the rail. You may not see the cracks with the box bolted on. Unbolt it if you can, or have someone rock the steering wheel while you watch for the frame moving. A properly welded reinforcement plate is fine; a bolt-on brace over an old crack isn't a fix.

- [ ] **Rust in the usual places**
  CK5 members list the rockers, the front floor and the front seat-belt anchors, the rear wheel arches, the tail pan, the bottoms of the doors and tailgate, the cab mounts and the rear floor supports by the tailgate hinges. Pull up the carpet and smell for mildew. If the paint is bubbling from outside, the rust underneath is usually already serious.

- [ ] **Tailgate window and top seal**
  Try the rear window. It winds down inside the tailgate by crank or motor, the motor and its drive cable are known to fail, and a safety switch stops the glass going up if the tailgate isn't latched. Ask whether the top has been removed. Owners disagree on whether that always causes leaks, but the seal between the top and the body is the usual leak point.

- [ ] **Is it really a 350?**
  One CK5 member warns about 305s being sold as 350s, engines described as 'rebuilt' that never were, and a TH350 in a truck that should have a 700R4. Look for clean grease between the engine and transmission, which suggests nothing has been apart. Check the freeze plugs for weeping.

- [ ] **Identify the axles and transfer case**
  On the front axle, a 10-bolt cover is nearly round with no flat sides, while the Dana 44 has the familiar Dana shape. Mismatched gear ratios front and rear, or a missing front driveshaft, mean someone has swapped parts. NP205 and NP203 cases carry ID tags above the front output. On 1989–91 NP241s, a leaking slip-yoke rear output is common.

- [ ] **Hubs and 4WD engagement**
  1981 and later trucks came with automatic locking hubs, which seize with age. One King of the Hammers K5 owner bought a truck with a 'blown transmission' that turned out to be a transfer case stuck in neutral and seized automatic hubs. Engage 4WD on the test drive, and budget for manual hubs.

- [ ] **Previous owners' work**
  Look for hacked-in wiring, stereos and lights, cheap lift blocks and poor welding. One CK5 member says to pay extra for a properly done one-ton axle swap (8-lug axles) rather than a cheaply lifted 6-lug truck. Another suggests 1987–91 trucks for fuel injection, with 1989–91 the favorites.

- [ ] **M1009 specifics**
  Check whether the 24/12-volt system is original or has been converted. If the resistor pack has been bypassed for 12-volt glow plugs, the starter, the alternator and the NATO slave receptacle in the grille also need dealing with. Expect 3.08 gears, 10.00-15 tires and a governed 55 mph top speed as delivered.

YEARS TO KNOW

1987	SWEET SPOT	Throttle-body injection on all gas engines, and the 350 becomes the standard engine. The trucks become the R/V series (V10 Blazer, V-Jimmy) as GMT400 pickups take the C/K name. In CK5 threads on which year to buy, most owners point to these 1987–91 TBI trucks for drivability and fuel economy
1989	SWEET SPOT	GMT400-style grille; NP241 transfer case; 30-spline 10-bolt axle shafts; serpentine belt on the 5.7. Cheyenne returns as the base Chevrolet trim. CK5 owners rate 1989–91 as the best of the TBI trucks for the NP241, the 30-spline shafts and the updated 700R4

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Rear brake drum balance weights can loosen aluminum wheels**
  1982 · NHTSA 82V128000
- [ ] **Composite front brake rotors can separate from corrosion**
  1988–1991 (Blazer listed for 1988–92) · NHTSA 93V119000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Front axle**
  Torque King says the GM 10-bolt front cover is an oval about 11 in high by 10-1/4 in wide with no flat sides, unlike the Dana 44 cover. GMSquareBody members also note the two small ears on the 10-bolt housing. Dana 44s are typical of 1973–76, either could be fitted in 1977–78, and the 10-bolt is typical from 1979. Dana 44 and 10-bolt shafts don't interchange.
- [ ] **Transfer case**
  NP205: a one-piece cast-iron case with a small three-bolt idler cover on the back and an ID tag above the front output. NP203: about 22–23 in long, in four bolted sections with a range box on the front and its tag on the chain case. NP208 (1981–88) and NP241 (1989–91) are aluminum, chain-driven cases, and the NP241's tag is on the rear of the case.
- [ ] **305 or 350?**
  CK5 members warn that 305s get sold as 350s. Wikipedia notes that 1981-on 305s used smaller 56 cc combustion chambers, against 76 cc. Check the casting numbers and the engine code before you pay a 350 price.

- [ ] **Year by the front end**
  1973–80 trucks mostly have round headlamps (Silverado-trim C/K trucks got square ones for 1980). From 1981 there's a new front end with available stacked square headlamps. The 1988 trucks lose the K5 badge and get a fender-mounted antenna. The 1989–91 trucks have the flatter, GMT400-style grille.

- [ ] **A real M1009**
  Genuine M1009s have the 6.2 diesel, a TH400 and an NP208, 10-bolt axles with 3.08 gears and an Eaton automatic rear locker, 10.00-15 tires, and a 24/12-volt system with two batteries, two alternators, a firewall glow-plug resistor pack and a NATO slave receptacle in the grille. Blackout lights, a brush guard and a rifle rack were standard.

- [ ] **Model naming**
  Chevrolet badges read K5 until 1988. GM officially called it the Full-Size Blazer from 1983 and the V10 / V1500 Blazer from 1987. GMC's twin was the Jimmy, then the K-Jimmy, then from 1987 the V-Jimmy.

NOTES

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